

— PARENT INTELLIGENCE REPORT

3 things to say instead of 'calm down'

Telling an angry child to calm down rarely works. Learn how to calm an angry child with co-regulation, naming feelings, and three phrases that actually settle big emotions.

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THE CHALLENGE PARENTS FACE

Your child is melting down in the cereal aisle. Face red, fists tight, the whole store watching. So you say the two words every parent says: "Calm down." And it does nothing. If anything, it pours fuel on the fire. Sound familiar?

— THE 30-SECOND ANSWER

3 things to say instead of 'calm down'

QUICK ANSWER

What is co-regulation? Co-regulation is when a calm adult helps a child settle their nervous system before the child can do it alone. A steady voice, a slow breath, a hand on the back — these borrow your calm and lend it to your child. Over many repeats, kids turn that borrowed calm into their own self-control.

— WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS

A 2025 study on parents' and toddlers' emotion talk found that children who hear feelings named build a stronger emotion vocabulary and better self-control.

Sources: Harvard | Neuroscience Society | Taylor & Francis | CDC

DO THIS

3 things to say instead of 'calm down'

Work through these in order. Small, consistent reps beat one big push.

1**"I'm right here"**

You're safe." — Safety first. The body settles before the mind can.

2**"You're so mad"**

Tell me with your words or show me." — Gives the feeling an exit that isn't hitting.

3**"Let's breathe together"**

In... and out." — You do it first; they follow your lead, not your order.

— KEEP AN EYE OUT

Name it to tame it: the move that actually works

- ✓ Wrong move: "Stop crying, it's not a big deal." → Message: your feeling is wrong.
- ✓ Right move: "You wanted more time. That's so frustrating." → Message: I get it, I'm here.
- ✓ Wrong move: "Calm down right now." → A demand a flooded brain can't obey.
- ✓ Right move: a calm voice and a slow breath they can copy. → A path back to calm.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

Quick answers for parents

Why does telling my child to calm down make it worse?

Because a child in meltdown has lost access to the thinking part of their brain. "Calm down" is a demand they physically can't meet in that moment, and it can feel like you're annoyed by their feeling. Help them settle first with a calm voice and presence.

What should I say instead of calm down?

Name the feeling and offer safety: "You're really angry, and I'm right here." Then breathe slowly so they can copy you. Connection settles the body; only then can the mind think clearly again.

Isn't naming feelings just rewarding bad behavior?

No. Naming a feeling isn't the same as approving an action. You can say "You're furious" and still hold the limit "but we don't hit." Naming calms the brain so the child can actually hear the limit.

How long should a meltdown take to pass?

It varies, but most storms ease within a few minutes once a child feels understood and safe. Fighting the feeling makes it last longer. Sitting beside it calmly makes it shorter.

My child is older — does this still work?

Yes. Co-regulation works for teens too. They're just as tuned to whether you're steady or reactive. Stay calm, name what you see, and skip the lecture until the wave has passed.

What if I lose my own calm?

It happens to every parent. Take your own slow breath first, or step back a moment if it's safe. You can't lend calm you don't have, so steady yourself before you steady them.

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